



ICSE 2027 EXAMINATION
SPECIMEN QUESTION PAPER
LITERATURE IN ENGLISH
(ENGLISH PAPER – 2)

Maximum Marks: 80

Time allowed: Two hours

Answers to this paper must be written on the paper provided separately.

You will not be allowed to write during the first 15 minutes.

This time is to be spent in reading the question paper.

The time given at the head of this paper is the time allowed for writing the answers.

*The paper has **four** Sections.*

Section A is compulsory – ***All*** questions in ***Section A*** must be answered.

*You must attempt **one** question from each of the **Sections B, C and D** and **one** other question from any Section of your choice.*

The intended marks for questions or parts of questions are given in brackets [].

Instruction for the Supervising Examiner

Kindly read aloud the Instructions given above to all the candidates present in the Examination Hall.

NOTE:

The Specimen Question Paper in the subject provides a realistic format of the Board Examination Question Paper and should be used as a practice tool. The questions for the Board Examination can be set from any part of the syllabus. However, the format of the Board Examination Question Paper will remain the same as that of the Specimen Question Paper.

SECTION A (40 Marks)

(Attempt **all** questions from this Section.)

Question 1

Choose the correct answers to the questions from the given options.

[16]

(Do not copy the question, write the correct answers only.)

- (i) What does Antony describe as, '*thou bleeding piece of earth*,'?
- (a) Caesar's robe that was stained with his blood
 - (b) The blood-soaked spot on which Caesar lies
 - (c) The bloodied pedestal on which Caesar fell
 - (d) Caesar's lifeless body covered in blood
- (ii) When Brutus says, '*ambition's debt is paid*', he means that:
- (a) Caesar's greed for power and position had resulted in his death.
 - (b) Caesar had left seventy-five drachmas for every citizen of Rome.
 - (c) Mark Antony would be permitted to speak at Caesar's funeral.
 - (d) the conspirators would be punished for assassinating Caesar.
- (iii) Brutus scolds Cassius for taking bribes and soon after complains that Cassius has not given him money. This shows that Brutus is _____.
- (a) hypocritical
 - (b) jealous
 - (c) miserly
 - (d) vengeful
- (iv) When Antony says, '*He must be taught, and train'd, and bid go forth: A barren-spirited fellow;*' he refers to _____.
- (a) Octavius
 - (b) Lucilius
 - (c) Lucius
 - (d) Lepidus

[Understanding]

[Understanding]

[Understanding]

[Recall]

(v) Which words best describe the death of Cinna the poet?

- (a) tragic and unnecessary
- (b) jealous and selfish
- (c) accidental and unintentional
- (d) justified and essential

[Analysis]

(vi) Which of the following words best describes Cassius's state of mind when he says:

*'Come, Antony, and young Octavius, come,
Revenge yourselves alone on Cassius,'*

- (a) anxious
- (b) regretful
- (c) fearful
- (d) frustrated

[Analysis]

(vii) In the poem, *'Haunted Houses'*, what does the speaker see at his fireside that the stranger cannot?

- (a) The speaker only sees what is physically present.
- (b) The stranger can see the spirits while the speaker cannot.
- (c) The speaker sees both the present and the past.
- (d) The stranger sees both the present and the future.

[Understanding]

(viii) In the poem, *'The Glove and the Lions'*, which words best describe the lady's action?

1. scornful
2. provocative
3. challenging

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 2 and 3
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

[Analysis]

- (ix) Select the option that shows the correct relationship between Statements I and II from Maya Angelou's poem, *'When Great Trees Fall'*:

Statement I: When great trees fall, the world is left permanently unstable.

Statement II: In the poem, the natural world is depicted as reacting with fear and uncertainty when great trees fall.

- (a) Both the statements are true.
- (b) Both the statements are false.
- (c) Statement I is true, but statement II is false.
- (d) Statement I is false, but statement II is true.

[Understanding]

- (x) The poem, *'A Considerable Speck'*, expresses Frost's _____.

- (a) love for the little organism
- (b) respect for intelligent life
- (c) indifference to the tiny creature
- (d) anger at the mite's escape

[Understanding]

- (xi) Which of the given options contains the figure of speech that appears in the following line from the poem, *'The Power of Music'*?

*'And in the sky the feathered fly turn turtle while
They're winging,'*

- (a) *'You're one month on in the middle of May'*
- (b) *'Rainbow-tinted circles of light'*
- (c) *'I wander'd lonely as a cloud'*
- (d) *'I babble on the pebbles.'*

[Application]

(xii) In the short story, '*With the Photographer*', the narrator asks the photographer,

'Is it me?' because he _____.

- (a) is delighted with the photographer's skill
- (b) looks very handsome in the photograph
- (c) is unable to recognise his own face
- (d) is ashamed of how he looks in the picture

[Understanding]

(xiii) Choose the option that lists the sequence of events from Alphonse Daudet's short story, '*The Last Lesson*':

1. Embarrassed and frightened, he entered his class expecting to be scolded.
2. On reaching his school, he found that it was unexpectedly quiet.
3. Instead, M. Hamel smiled at him and told him to go to his place.
4. Franz ran past the town hall and the crowd in front of the bulletin board on his way to school.

- (a) 2, 1, 3, 4
- (b) 1, 3, 4, 2
- (c) 3, 1, 4, 2
- (d) 4, 2, 1, 3

[Understanding]

(xiv) Which aspect of our world today makes it most similar to Leonard Mead's world in '*The Pedestrian*'?

- (a) isolation and alienation
- (b) low crime rate
- (c) no night traffic
- (d) Utopian society

[Analysis]

(xv) At the end of the story, ‘*The Girl Who Can*’, Adjoa thinks,

‘But that’s how I was feeling and thinking all along’

This suggests that Adjoa had known that _____.

- (a) she would win the cup for best all-round junior athlete
- (b) Nana had always been right about her legs
- (c) her legs were useful for more than child-bearing
- (d) Maami was right about the importance of education

[Understanding]

(xvi) In the short story, ‘*The Elevator*’, which of the following does Martin’s father **NOT** do when Martin expresses his fear of the elevator?

- (a) He dismisses Martin’s concerns.
- (b) He encourages Martin to use the stairs.
- (c) He tells Martin to grow up and be brave.
- (d) He watches TV and ignores Martin’s fear.

[Understanding]

SECTION B (40 Marks)

(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section.)

DRAMA

(Julius Caesar by William Shakespeare)

Question 2

Read the extract from ‘*Julius Caesar*’ Act 3, Scene 2, given below, and answer the questions that follow:

Antony: *Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears;*

I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him.

The evil that men do lives after them,

The good is oft interred with their bones;

So let it be with Caesar. The noble Brutus

Hath told you Caesar was ambitious;

If it were so, it was a grievous fault,

And grievously hath Caesar answer'd it.

Here, under leave of Brutus and the rest—

For Brutus is an honourable man;

So are they all, all honourable men—

Come I to speak in Caesar's funeral.

- (i) What does Antony say he is there for? [3]
 What does he say he is **not** there for? [Understanding & Analysis]
 What does this tell you about him?
- (ii) Mention *any two* of the conditions that Brutus had laid down before [3]
 allowing Antony to speak to the citizens of Rome. Why do you think [Recall & Analysis]
 he laid down these conditions?
- (iii) List *any two* arguments that Antony uses immediately after he speaks [3]
 these lines to prove conclusively that Julius Caesar was not ambitious. [Recall & Understanding]
 What impact do his words have on the listening Romans?
- (iv) Which *one* argument of Antony's do you think had the greatest impact [3]
 on his listeners? Give reasons to support your answer. [Evaluation & Understanding]
- (v) Explain the following lines: [4]
'The evil that men do lives after them,
The good is oft interred with their bones;'
 How can these lines be applied to Brutus and Caesar? [Comprehension & Analysis]

Question 3

Read the extract from '*Julius Caesar*' Act 5, Scene 1, given below, and answer the questions that follow:

Cassius: *Then, if we lose this battle,*
You are contented to be led in triumph
Through the streets of Rome?

Brutus: *No, Cassius, no: think not, thou noble Roman,*
That ever Brutus will go bound to Rome;

*He bears too great a mind. But this same day
Must end that work the ides of March begun;
And whether we shall meet again I know not.
Therefore our everlasting farewell take:
Forever, and forever, farewell, Cassius.
If we do meet again, why, we shall smile;
If not, why then, this parting was well made.*

- (i) Why does Brutus say, 'No, Cassius, no'? [3]
[Understanding]
What conditions may force Brutus to go bound to Rome?
Brutus says, 'And whether we shall meet again I know not.' What do these words imply? [Analysis]
- (ii) Explain the following lines in your own words: [3]
*'Therefore our everlasting farewell take:
Forever, and forever, farewell, Cassius.'*
How do these words hint at the manner of Cassius and Brutus' death? [Understanding]
- (iii) How does Brutus die? [3]
How does his manner of dying contradict the philosophy by which he had lived his life? [Recall & Analysis]
- (iv) At the end of the play, Antony calls Brutus, 'the noblest Roman of them all'. Why does he say this? What does this reveal of Antony's character? [3]
[Understanding & Analysis]
- (v) What strange occurrence had Cassius observed when his army was marching from Sardis to Philippi? What impact did he admit the experience have on him? [4]
[Understanding]

SECTION C

(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section.)

PROSE - SHORT STORIES

(Treasure Chest – A Collection of Short Stories and Poems)

Question 4

Read the following extract from William Sleator's short story, 'The Elevator' and answer the questions that follow:

'Martin felt nervous when he got back to the building after school. But why should he be afraid of an old lady? He felt ashamed of himself. He pressed the button and stepped into the elevator, hoping that it would not stop, but it stopped on the third floor. Martin watched the door slide open ...'

- | | | |
|-------|--|-----------------------------------|
| (i) | Why was Martin afraid of using this particular elevator? What does this tell us about him? | [3]
[Recall & Analysis] |
| (ii) | Describe the person who entered the elevator when the door slid open. How did this person make Martin feel? | [3]
[Recall] |
| (iii) | 'He felt ashamed of himself.' Why did Martin feel this way? How was his response shaped by his father's opinion of him? | [3]
[Analysis] |
| (iv) | How does the story end? Bring out the element of horror in the ending of the story. | [3]
[Recall & Analysis] |
| (v) | Why was Martin nervous when his father got out of the lift on the ninth floor? Give two words to describe the ending of the story. | [4]
[Understanding & Analysis] |

Question 5

Read the following extract from Alphonse Daudet's short story, 'The Last Lesson', and answer the questions that follow:

"My children, this is the last lesson I shall give you. The order has come from Berlin to teach only German in the schools of Alsace and Lorraine. The new master comes tomorrow. This is your last French lesson. I want you to be very attentive."

What a thunder-clap these words were to me!

Oh, the wretches; that was what they had put up at the town-hall!

- (i) Who was M. Hamel? Which *one* of his character traits as a teacher do you find most appealing? [3]
[Recall & Evaluation]
- (ii) Who else was present in the classroom on that day besides M. Hamel and the students? What feelings do you think these persons experienced as they sat in the classroom? [3]
[Recall & Analysis]
- (iii) What felt different to Franz when he arrived late for school that morning? [3]
[Understanding]
- (iv) What is Franz's biggest regret about school? What aspects of his character do you relate to? [3]
[Understanding & Evaluation]
- (v) What feeling does the expression '*thunder-clap*' suggest? Use the expression in a sentence of your own with the same meaning as it appears in the passage. Mention **one** important lesson M. Hamel taught his students during his '*last French lesson*'? Give a reason for your choice. [4]
[Understanding, Application & Creativity]

SECTION D

(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section.)

POETRY

(Treasure Chest – A Collection of Short Stories and Poems)

Question 6

Read the following extract from Leigh Hunt's poem, '*The Glove and the Lions*' and answer the questions that follow:

*And truly 'twas a gallant thing to see that crowning show,
Valour and love, and a king above, and the royal beasts below.*

- (i) Describe the scene at the beginning of the poem. [3]
[Recall]
- (ii) "Leigh Hunt uses vivid sound and visual images to describe the contest between the royal beasts in the pit." Justify the statement with close reference to the text. [3]
[Analysis]

- (iii) Who was the '*beauteous lively dame*' mentioned in the poem? What did she do? Why did she do this? [3]
[Understanding & Analysis]
- (iv) When King Francis exclaims, '*rightly done!*', what action of Count de Lorge does he applaud? Why do you think the Count behaved the way he did? Give a reason for your response. [3]
[Understanding & Analysis]
- (v) Explain, in your own words, what the poet means by '*smiling lips*' and '*sharp bright eyes*' when he describes de Lorge's beloved. If you had to give the poem a title of your own, what would it be? Give *one* reason to justify your choice. [4]
[Understanding, Creativity & Evaluation]

Question 7

Read the following extract from Robert Frost's poem, '*A Considerable Speck*' and answer the questions that follow:

This was no dust speck by my breathing blown,

But unmistakably a living mite

With inclinations it could call its own.

- (i) What did the narrator first imagine the '*speck*' to be? What does his use of the words '*speck*' and '*mite*' tell us about it? [3]
[Recall & Understanding]
- (ii) What was the narrator doing when he spotted the speck? Which **two** words from the poem helped you come to this conclusion? [3]
[Recall]
- (iii) What made him realise that he was dealing with '*an intelligence*'? [3]
[Understanding & Analysis]
- (iv) What actions of the mite led the narrator to conclude that the mite had feet? [3]
[Understanding]
- (v) Describe the narrator's initial response to the speck. What did he eventually decide to do about it? Why does he make this decision? [4]
[Understanding & Analysis]
Give *one* word to describe the **tone** of the poem.

ICSE 2027 SPECIMEN

DRAFT MARKING SCHEME – LITERATURE IN ENGLISH (ENGLISH PAPER 2)

Question 1		[16]
(i)	(d) Caesar's lifeless body covered in blood	
(ii)	(a) Caesar's greed for power and position had resulted in his death.	
(iii)	(a) hypocritical	
(iv)	(d) Lepidus	
(v)	(a) tragic and unnecessary	
(vi)	(d) frustrated	
(vii)	(c) The speaker sees both the present and the past.	
(viii)	(b) 2 and 3	
(ix)	(d) Statement I is false, but statement II is true.	
(x)	(b) respect for intelligent life	
(xi)	(a) 'You're one month on in the middle of May'	
(xii)	(c) is unable to recognise his own face	
(xiii)	(d) 4, 2, 1, 3	
(xiv)	(a) isolation and alienation	
(xv)	(c) her legs were useful for more than child-bearing	
(xvi)	(b) He encourages Martin to use the stairs.	
Question 2		
<i>The answers provided are indicative only. Any other correct and relevant answers, supported by appropriate reasoning where applicable, should also be accepted.</i>		
(i)	-What does Antony say he is there for? - to bury Caesar -What does he say he is not there for? NOT to praise Caesar -What does this tell you about him? - manipulative / deceptive	[1+1+1]
(ii)	-Conditions laid down by Brutus: - Brutus would speak first - Antony would say he was speaking with the permission of the conspirators - Antony would not blame the conspirators	[2+1]

	• Antony should speak well of Caesar • Antony would speak from the same pulpit as Brutus (Any two) - Personal response Question: Please accept any plausible response along the lines of: • Anxious that Antony might influence the crowd • Cassius had warned him against allowing Antony to speak • Brutus was being cautious	
(iii)	-Two arguments that Antony uses: • Caesar brought many captives to Rome (their ransoms filled the general coffer) • Caesar wept with the poor • Caesar refused the crown thrice (at the feast of Lupercal) (Any two) -Impact: • Convinced by Antony's words that Caesar was not ambitious / stirred to rage against the conspirators	[2+1]
(iv)	Personal response Question: Please accept any plausible response along the lines of: • Caesar wept • Caesar refused the crown • Ransoms filled the general coffer • Caesar's robe • Caesar's mutilated body • Caesar's will (Any one) Any two reasons to support your answer. Justifications must match reasons.	[1+2]
(v)	-Explanation: • People remember only our wrongdoings • And forget our good deeds after we die -How can these lines be applied to Brutus and Caesar? • After Brutus' death, he is remembered for having betrayed his friend / disloyalty • Caesar is remembered for his ambition and greed	[1+1] [1+1]

Question 3		
(i)	-Why Brutus says, ‘No, Cassius, no’. - When Cassius asks him if he is willing to go bound to Rome, Brutus responds vehemently in these words – to communicate that he would never allow himself to be taken through the streets of Rome as captive. - Conditions that may force Brutus to go bound to Rome. - If they lose the battle / If Brutus were taken captive -What do these words imply? - Implies uncertainty about the outcome of the battle / resigned to his fate / either may die in battle	[1] [1] [1]
(ii)	-Explanation of lines: - Implies the possibility of death and defeat How do these words hint at the manner of Cassius and Brutus’ death- - Hints at their defeat - That they will not meet again - Their tragic deaths (Any two)	[1] [2]
(iii)	-How does Brutus die? - Takes his own life / Runs on his sword held by Strato -Contradiction: - Brutus had believed in the Stoic philosophy which accepts suffering and joy with equanimity - but Brutus was unwilling to accept the humiliation of defeat at the hands of the Second Triumvirate and kills himself	[1+2]
(iv)	-Reason: - Brutus was the only conspirator who participated in the assassination of Caesar without envy of Caesar - Motivated by the common good of Rome - Elements of Nature perfectly balanced in Brutus - Nature would proclaim that Brutus was an ideal man -What does this reveal of Antony’s character? - Noble - acknowledges greatness even in an enemy - Values honour (Any one)	[2+1]

(v)	-strange occurrence: • Two eagles had accompanied them from Sardis to Philippi • They had fled that morning • Replaced by scavenging birds - ravens, crows, kites (Any two) -Impact: • Cassius had followed the Epicurean philosophy and not believed in omens • Now he admits to partly believing in portents/ superstitions	[2+2]
Question 4		
(i)	-Why was Martin afraid of using this particular elevator? • Poorly lit • Dirty walls • Very small • Felt claustrophobic / trapped • Doors closed quickly • Shuddered when it moved • Afraid it would fall (Any two) -What does this tell us about him? Personal Response Question. Accept plausible responses on the lines of - lacking in confidence/ anxious/ insecure etc. (Any one)	[2+1]
(ii)	-Describe the person who entered the elevator when the door slid open. • Fat lady / in green overcoat / piggish face / tiny / sharp / blue eyes / large fleshy cheeks / no chin / mass of neck (Any two) -How did this person make Martin feel? • Terrified / felt threatened by her presence / nervous (Any one)	[2+1]
(iii)	-Why did Martin feel this way? • Ashamed of being labelled a coward / that he should be afraid of an old lady -How was his response shaped by his father's opinion of him? • His father always humiliated him • expected he would behave like a 'man' • Wanted him to act like a grown-up • Thought Martin was meek / weak / timid / cowardly (Any two)	[1+2]

(iv)	-How does the story end? • Martin on crutches alone with the fat lady in the elevator • Trapped / cannot escape • Elevator door closes • She smiles and says 'Hello Martin' (Any two) -Bring out the element of horror in the ending. • Martin trapped with the lady in the elevator / suspense / sinister smile / Calls him by name though they have never met (Any one)	[2+1]
(v)	-Why was Martin nervous when his father got out of the lift on the ninth floor? • Martin had broken his leg / Was on crutches • Knew he would not be able to escape if the lady entered the elevator -Give <i>two</i> words to describe the ending of the story. Personal Response Question. Accept plausible responses on the lines of- • Cliff-hanger • Open-ended • Horrifying • Suspenseful (Any two)	[2+2]
Question 5		
(i)	-Who was M. Hamel? • Teacher at the village school • Taught French -Which <i>one</i> of his character traits as a teacher do you find most appealing? Personal response Question: Please accept any plausible response	[2+1]
(ii)	-Who else was present in the classroom on that day besides M. Hamel and the students? • The elderly village folk -What feelings do you think these persons experienced as they sat in the classroom? • Felt deep respect for M. Hamel's services to the village • Ashamed of not having given enough importance to their language • Regret at having neglected education (Any two)	[1+2]

(iii)	-What felt different to Franz when he arrived late for school that morning? • Everyone was quiet • Students all seated • The usual bustle was missing	[3]
(iv)	-What is Franz's biggest regret about school? • Not having learnt French when he had the chance / now he would never learn any more -What aspects of his character do you relate to? Personal response Question: Please accept any plausible response along the lines of – typical boy; finding lessons boring / inattentive etc. (Any two)	[1+2]
(v)	-What feeling does the expression 'thunder-clap' suggest? • Shocked/stunned etc. -Use the expression in a sentence of your own with the same meaning as it appears in the passage. • Personal response - grammatically correct sentence using the same meaning as in the passage -One important lesson M. Hamel taught his students during his 'last French lesson' • To learn to love one's language • Importance of knowing one's mother tongue • Patriotism • Language is the key to freedom for enslaved people (Any 1) -Give a reason for your choice. • Personal response- justification must match response	[1] [1] [1] [1]
Question 6		
(i)	Scene at the beginning of the poem- • King Francis, nobles, ladies seated together • Watching the lions fight in pit • Count de Lorge sighing for his beloved	[3]
(ii)	• Visual images: Laughing jaws / glared / gave blows like beams / rolled on one another / bloody foam whisked through the air • Sound images: Lions roared / stifled roar / thunderous smother	[3]
(iii)	-Who was the 'beauteous lively dame' mentioned in the poem? • De Lorge's beloved / girl / girlfriend / lady love / lover	[1+1+1]

	-What did she do? • Dropped her glove into the lions' pit -Why did she do this? • Seeing the opportunity to test de Lorge's love / to win attention-admiration for herself / to attain glory / vanity • She overheard the King say, 'Faith, gentlemen, we're better here than there.' (Any one)	
(iv)	-Action of Count de Lorge • Flinging / throwing the glove • in the lady's face / at the lady (Any one) -Why do you think the Count behaved the way he did? Personal response: Please accept any plausible justification such as- • Disillusioned / no longer finds her attractive / sees through her vanity / cunning motive / realised that this was not true love / angry with her (Any one) -Give a reason for your response Personal response: Please accept any plausible reasons such as- • To humiliate / shame her (Any one)	[1+1+1]
(v)	-<i>'smiling lips'</i> and <i>'sharp bright eyes'</i> – • Artificial / fake smile / <u>expressionless</u> • Shrewd / cunning, sharp eyes -If you had to give the poem a title of your own, what would it be? Give one reason to justify your choice. Personal response: Please accept any suitable title plus any plausible justification.	[1+1] [1+1]
Question 7		
(i)	-What did the narrator first imagine the '<i>speck</i>' to be? • A dust particle -What does his use of the words '<i>speck</i>' and '<i>mite</i>' tell us about it? • Size = Little / tiny / small • Insignificant/ unimportant/ Living creature	[1] [1+1]

(ii)	-What was the narrator doing when he spotted the speck? • Writing -Which two words from the poem helped you come to this conclusion? • Paper / ink / manuscript / pen <i>(Any two)</i>	[1] [1+1]
(iii)	What made him realise that he was dealing with ‘an intelligence’? Response to stimulus: • paused suspicious of his pen / raced wildly / loathing for the smell / taste of ink / ran terrified / crept cunningly / faltered / cowered / desperate to survive. <i>(Any three)</i>	[3]
(iv)	Movement: Ran (with terror) / raced / Crept / Faltered / tried to get away / escape death / turned to flee <i>(Any three)</i>	[3]
(v)	-narrator’s initial response: • He wanted to stop it with his pen / drop of ink -What did he eventually decide to do about it? • Let it lie there, till it slept -Why does he make this decision? • respect for intelligent life / it was harmless / not evil / had a mind of its own / Sensitive to life forms no matter how small / Appreciates intelligence / Respect for life <i>(Any one)</i> -Give one word to describe the tone of the poem. • Personal Response along the lines of: Philosophical / reflective / meditative or their equivalent.	[1+1+1+1]